

Steroids for brain tumours

Steroids are often prescribed to reduce swelling around brain tumours. This can help to manage symptoms such as headaches or feeling sick.

Drugs called steroids are given to help reduce the swelling around [brain tumours](#). They can make you feel better by improving the [symptoms](#) caused by increased pressure inside the skull, such as headaches. The most commonly used steroid is called dexamethasone.

You may have steroids before, during and after your main [brain tumour treatment](#). It is important to take them exactly as your nurse or doctor has explained. Your pharmacist or nurse will give you a steroid card. Always carry this card with you. It means in an emergency a doctor or nurse will know you are taking steroids.

Never stop taking your steroids suddenly, as this can make you ill. Your doctor will give you advice about slowly reducing the dose when it is time to stop taking them.

Side effects of steroids

Steroids can cause the following side effects:

- Indigestion – taking your tablets with food will help. Tell your doctor if you have tummy pain. They may prescribe drugs to help or prevent this.
- Increased appetite and weight gain – if you are worried about gaining weight, talk to your doctor or nurse.
- Difficulty sleeping – taking your tablets in the morning may help your sleep.
- Feeling restless or agitated – tell your doctor if this is a problem.
- Raised blood sugar levels – tell your clinical nurse specialist or doctor if you are always thirsty or peeing more often than usual. You may need a simple blood or urine test to check your blood sugar levels.

Taking high doses of steroids for a long time may cause more side effects. These can include:

- mood changes, such as feeling sad
- swollen feet and legs
- raised blood pressure.

You may also be more likely to get an infection. Your muscles may get weaker, especially at the tops of your legs. It is important to do some regular, gentle exercise.

Talk to your doctor or specialist nurse if you are worried about any side effects. These will go away over time as your steroids are reduced.

We have more information about [steroids](#).

Brain cancer forum

Join our online community forum to chat with other people who have been affected by brain tumours, share your experience, and ask questions.

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 May 2024 | Next review: 01 May 2027